his chances again in the top seat if he comes close to senior ally BJP in terms of seats. A share in power is vital for the CM to keep his flock together. But the Mahayuti has not named him CM candidate, so he is in the same boat as ex-boss Thackeray. The MVA has so far spurned the SS(UBT)'s demands to announce a chief ministerial nominee. The Thackeray camp says announcing him as the candidate will help retain the fence-sitters in the UBT camp and may even entice some of those who migrated to the Shinde side.

For both factions, it's a desperate battle for survival—an MVA win could obliterate Shinde while a win for the Mahayuti could see the Thackerays being reduced to bit players in the future. Which is why ex-MP Rahul Shewale of the Shinde Sena says schemes like Ladki Bahin will set the narrative. Indeed, this election, the campaign seems all about MVA's 'Maharashtra pride' versus the Mahayuti's '*labharthi* (beneficiary)' schemes. "Each assembly seat has some 70,000 women Ladki Bahin beneficiaries," Shewale points out. "Even if 50 per cent vote for us, we'll gain in the multi-cornered fights."

AN MVA WIN COULD OBLITERATE SHINDE, WHILE A WIN FOR THE MAHAYUTI COULD SEE THE THACKERAYS BEING REDUCED TO BIT PLAYERS IN THE FUTURE

Meanwhile, the MVA wants to keep the focus on what Congress general secretary Sachin Sawant calls the "political debauchery" of splitting two big parties using the "might of the central agencies". MVA leaders also poke holes in the plan to use welfare schemes as a poll plank, claiming that while the populist spending has upset the middle classes, a bulk of the beneficiaries could well be Muslims and Dalits, not natural Mahayuti voters.



MANDAR DEODHAR

PAWAR VS PAWAR

Speaking at a public meeting at Phaltan in Satara, where ex-royal Sanjeevraje Naik Nimbalkar and local NCP MLA Deepak Chavan joined his faction, NCP(SP) chief Sharad Pawar struck a defiant note. "Don't worry...84 years or 90, this old man will not stop. This old man will not rest till he ensures that Maharashtra is on the right track," thundered the octogenarian Pawar. In July 2023, when nephew Ajit had walked out on him with a majority of the NCP's legislators to join the Mahayuti, the media had asked Pawar Sr who would now be the "*ashwasak chehra* (reassuring face)" of the party. "Sharad Pawar," Pawar responded laconically. The subsequent turn of events proved him right.

In the 10 seats that the NCP (SCP) fought in Lok Sabha election, it won eight, while Ajit's NCP managed just one of the four seats it contested. The senior Pawar also inflicted a crushing defeat on his nephew in family pocket borough Baramati, where his daughter Supriya Sule convincingly trounced sister-in-law Sunetra Pawar, Ajit's wife. This despite Ajit, like the Sena before him, walking away with the NCP name and official clock symbol, forcing the Sharad camp to go for a new name